

Lampropeltis triangulum

Milksnake



**Length** 1¼–6½ ft  
(0.4–2 m)  
**Breeding** Oviparous  
**Habit** Terrestrial  
**Status** Not evaluated

**Location** North America,  
Central America, N. South  
America



The milksnake is one of the world's most widely distributed terrestrial snakes, and also one of the most variable. About 24 subspecies have been identified, with 8 in the United States alone. Most are brightly colored, with red, black, and yellow bands; in some subspecies, the patterning is very similar to that of coral snakes (see p.400)—a feature that probably evolved as a form of defensive mimicry. Milksnakes are secretive, mainly nocturnal, and feed on invertebrates, amphibians, and small rodents, as well as other snakes. Although nonvenomous, they defend themselves by biting, and by discharging a foul-smelling fluid from the cloaca. Females build nests in burrows, under rocks, in tree stumps, or in rotting vegetation, and lay up to 17 eggs.



**BODY MARKINGS**  
The milksnake is usually red, black, and white, the markings arranged as rings around the body or as saddles over the back.

STARTLING DEFENSE

The milksnake is not venomous. It does, however, mimic the coloration, markings, and even behavior of venomous coral snakes and is easily confused with them in parts of its range. If uncovered from its hiding place, it may thrash around in an attempt to startle its prey with its bright colors.



Lamprophis fuliginosus

Brown house snake



**Length** 3–5 ft  
(0.9–1.5 m)  
**Breeding** Oviparous  
**Habit** Terrestrial  
**Status** Not evaluated

**Location** Africa (mainly  
south of Sahara)



The brown house snake is a powerful constrictor that actively forages at night for its prey—mainly rodents, but also birds and lizards. It may be tan, brown, orange, or black, with a cream stripe on either side of its head. The male is smaller than the female but has a proportionately longer tail. Females may lay 2 or more clutches of 6–16 eggs per breeding season. This snake may bite if provoked by predators, usually birds of prey or mammals, but it is not venomous.



slender, smooth-scaled body

Langaha madagascariensis

Madagaskan leaf-nosed snake



**Length** 28–35 in  
(70–90 cm)  
**Breeding** Oviparous  
**Habit** Arboreal  
**Status** Least concern

**Location** Madagascar



This snake is instantly recognizable because of its extraordinary snout. The male has a long, pointed projection on the snout tip; in the female, the appendage is more elaborate and leaf-shaped. Males are light brown with a yellow underside, while females are gray-brown with small, dark markings. Both sexes have a long, slender, vinelike body, which provides excellent camouflage in the vines and branches of their forest habitat. Active during the day and at night, they ambush lizards and frogs.

Natrix natrix

Grass snake



**Length** 4–6½ ft  
(1.2–2 m)  
**Breeding** Oviparous  
**Habit** Semiaquatic  
**Status** Least concern

**Location** Europe to  
C. Asia, N.W. Africa



The grass snake is a semiaquatic predator, spending much of its time in damp places or in still water. A good swimmer, it can sometimes be spotted rippling its way across the surface of ponds, in search of frogs and fishes. It is one of the most widespread snakes in Europe. Adults are olive-brown, greenish, or gray, usually with a contrasting yellow or white collar just behind the head. Female grass snakes are larger than males, and have longer, thicker tails. After mating, they sometimes lay their eggs at shared nest sites, where the total egg count can reach 200 or more. In places where

EGG-LAYING

Eggs are laid in decaying vegetation, manure or compost heaps, or other warm locations. Hatchlings measure 5½–8½ in (14–21 cm) long. Males reach maturity in 3 years, females in 4.

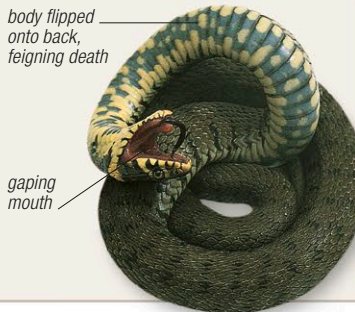


yellow collar

PLAYING DEAD

The grass snake ejects a foul-smelling fluid if handled, and sometimes reacts to extreme danger by playing dead. To make the performance as convincing as possible, it turns partly upside down, with its mouth open and tongue exposed.

body flipped  
onto back,  
feigning death



gaping  
mouth

summers are cool, females often lay their eggs in compost heaps, the warmth of decaying vegetation helping incubation. The grass snake has a lifespan of approximately 15 years in captivity.

Nerodia fasciata

Southern water snake



**Length** 1½–5 ft  
(0.5–1.5 m)  
**Breeding** Viviparous  
**Habit** Aquatic  
**Status** Least concern

**Location** C. and S.E. USA



Also known as the banded water snake, this species has a thickset body with keeled scales and highly variable coloration, sometimes with dark bands or blotches. Its eyes are situated toward the top of its head, helping it to see while partially submerged. This snake hunts for frogs and fishes during the day or night, depending on the temperature. If attacked, it may smear its captor with the foul-smelling contents of its anal gland. Many males may successfully mate with the same female. The female gives birth to 2–57 live young.



dark bands  
across body